English Department

Introduction to the Research Process

Unit

2nd Year LMD

Study Skills

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“Research is formalized curiosity. It is poking and prying with a purpose.”
– Zara Neale Hurston (1891-1960)

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1. Introduction

Students are likely to hear terminology like "statistics," "reliability," "sampling," and "validity" when they first encounter research methodology in the field of social sciences and humanities. These terms make this field exceedingly sophisticated and technical, as well as rather daunting. In fact, for the lay person, the image of a social scientist submitting the outcomes of Likert-scale items from a stratified random sample to structural equation modeling is not much more plausible than the image of a somber-looking natural scientist in a white coat performing a variety of odd experiments in a lab.

Such specialized language and visual representations imply that research is something that only professionals should conduct, and that regular people should avoid. In this course, I would like to present a more approachable aspect of research in an effort to demonstrate that anyone can undertake studies that produce worthwhile results with a little caution and common sense. I do hope that by the end of this course, most students would agree that **“you can do it if you really want”** (Dörnyei, 2011, p.15).

First of all, acquiring information is the main purpose of research. These days, "information" seems to be everywhere. In addition to the Web, there are many

new magazines that are crammed into the magazine racks alongside the old, well-known names in bookstores. There are countless helpful (and unhelpful, but perhaps interesting) websites.

We all have daily queries or issues that require solutions. The answer might be as simple as looking it up in the phone book, but more often than not, the solution will take more effort. We frequently have to collect information, evaluate it, organize it so that it is valuable to us, and then apply it as part of a project at school, college, university, the workplace, or at home.

So, what is research? How research can be defined? What is the essence of research?

2. What is Research?

In reality, there are a number of approaches to find the answers to our queries. These techniques range from being quite informal and relying on clinical observations to being fully scientific and following to accepted scientific practices. One technique to get the answers to your queries is through research. When you state that you are conducting research to learn the answers to a topic, you are suggesting that the following procedure will be used:

1. Is being carried out within the parameters of a particular philosophy;
2. Employs methodologies, methods, and procedures that have been tried, tested, and examined for their reliability and validity; and
3. Is intended to be impartial and unbiased.

Your philosophical perspective may be influenced by one of the many paradigms and research methodologies, including positivist, interpretive, phenomenological, action or participatory, feminist, qualitative, quantitative, and the academic field in which you were educated. Any step in the research process can be considered to have "validity," which is defined as having a basis based on reality. It guarantees that the right procedures were used to discover answers to a question in a research study. A measurement procedure's "reliability" is its capacity for accuracy and repeatability (able to be trusted). In order to be "unbiased and objective," you must have approached each decision objectively, reached each result to the best of your ability, and avoided injecting personal prejudice. In this instance, bias and subjectivity are distinguished. Bias is a mental propensity, an unjustified preference, or a prejudice. Your

subjectivity, which is a crucial component of your style of thinking, is "conditioned" by your educational background, field of study, philosophical perspective, life experiences, and skill set. An anthropological or a historian may approach a piece of material differently than a psychologist does, for instance. Contrarily, bias is a conscious effort to either hide or accentuate something. The process can be referred to as "research" if it meets the three aforementioned requirements. Therefore, it is implied that the method(s) you are using will satisfy these expectations when you claim that you are conducting a research study to discover the answer to a question.

You should be aware, as research novices, that research is not exclusively technical, intricate, statistical, or computer-based. It could be a pretty basic exercise created to offer solutions to straightforward inquiries about daily activities. However, research techniques can also be used to develop complex ideas or rules that control our daily life. As previously indicated, the method through which we come up with solutions to our research problems distinguishes research from non-research activities. A procedure must fulfill specific criteria and exhibit certain traits in order to be referred to as research. Let us look at several definitions of research to pinpoint these specifications and traits:

The word ***research*** is composed of two syllables, ***re*** and ***search.*** The dictionary defines the former as a prefix meaning again, anew or over again and the latter as a verb meaning to examine closely and carefully, to test and try, or to probe. Together they form a noun describing a careful, systematic, patient study and investigation in some field of knowledge, undertaken to establish facts or principles (Grinnell, 1993, p. 4).

According to Francis Bacon, research refers to any finding that first seems unbelievable, and once it has been made, it seems incredible that it should have eluded men's research for so long, giving rise to the reasonable expectation that a significant number of interventions will still be made.

Grinnell further adds: “research is a structured inquiry that utilizes acceptable scientific methodology to solve problems and creates new knowledge that is generally applicable” (Grinnell, 1993, p.4).

Literally, research is the systematic investigation into and study of materials and sources in order to establish facts and reach new conclusions.

Synonyms: investigation, experimentation, testing, exploration, analysis, fact-finding, examination, scrutiny, scrutinization, probing; groundwork; (rare) indagation, experiments, tests, enquiries, studies, analyses, work.

Example, "a group set up to oppose the use of animals in medical research"

Etymology:

The word *research* is derived from the Middle French (16th Century) "*recherche*", which means "to go about seeking", the term itself being derived from the Old French term "*recerchier*" a compound word from "re-" (expressing intensive force) + "cerchier", or "sercher", meaning 'search'. The earliest recorded use of the term was in 1577 (Merriam Webster Dictionary, 2017).

It is a careful study or investigation especially in order to discover new facts or information (Oxford Learner Advanced Encyclopedic Dictionary,1998).

It is a systematic investigation to establish facts or principles or to collect information on a subject. Verb: to carry out investigations into a subject or a problem. Research comes from old French (Recercher); meaning to seek. Search again: Re+cercher: To search (Collins English Dictionary, 2017).

Simply said, research is the process of looking for and acquiring data, usually in order to find an answer to a question or solve a problem. Numerous sorts and levels of complexity of research projects are a crucial component of the university experience and provide you with the chance to develop a priceless set of skills. In fact, a big part of what it means to be educated is the capacity to find and assess knowledge, which is the basis of research and a useful talent in many aspects of life.

Research in common parlance refers to a search for knowledge. It may be defined as a scientific and systematic search for pertinent information on a specific topic/area. In fact, research is an art of scientific investigation. The Advanced Learner's Dictionary of Current English lays down the meaning of research as "a careful investigation or inquiry especially through search for new facts in any branch of knowledge". Redman and Mory define research as "a systematized effort to gain new knowledge". Some people consider research as a movement, a movement from known to unknown. It is actually a voyage of discovery.

In its most basic form, "research" simply refers to the process of looking for answers to problems, which is something we all do constantly to better understand the world we live in. Let us use a really concrete example, such as trying to find a music CD for the cheapest price. To achieve this, we can visit various stores to compare prices, and these days we can even look online for the greatest deal. This entire time, we are conducting "research." Even if we find what appears to be a really fantastic price, we will not know whether a store or website that we have not visited is offering it, so it is not necessarily smart research, I acknowledge, another store might have offered the same CD for even cheaper. To do good research we need to be systematic so that by the end we can stand by our results with confidence. That is, research in the scientific sense is “the organized, systematic search for answers to questions we ask” (Hatch and Lazaraton, 1991, p. 1, cited in Dörnyei, 2011, p.15).

A logical, methodical search for fresh, pertinent knowledge on a certain subject is known as research. In the popular children's song "Twinkle Twinkle Little Star," The phrase "How I Wonder What You Are" effectively defines research through the usage of the words how and what. It examines how objective, methodical analysis might be used to identify solutions to scientific and societal challenges. It is a quest for knowledge, or the discovery of undiscovered facts. Here, knowledge refers to information on a subject. The data may come from a variety of sources, including experience, people, books, journals, nature, etc. A study may produce fresh insights that add to our body of knowledge. Progress in a field can only be made via research.

Indeed, civilization is based on research, which also determines a country's economic, social, and political development. The findings of scientific inquiry frequently need a change in the philosophical approach to issues that go well beyond the narrow scope of science itself. Research is not just limited to the fields of science and technology. Other fields of study that include language, literature, history, and sociology cover a wide range of topics. Whatever the subject, research must be an engaged, thorough, and methodical process of inquiry in order to uncover, understand, or modify facts, events, behaviors, and hypotheses. Study and development also include using the findings of research to further understanding in other fields or to improve the quality of human life.

Studies, experiments, observations, analyses, comparisons, and reasoning are used to conduct research. In reality, research is all around us. For instance, we are aware that smoking cigarettes is bad for your health, that heroin is addictive,

that cow dung is a good source of biogas, that the virus protozoan plasmodium causes malaria, and that the virus HIV causes AIDS (Acquired Immuno Deficiency Syndrome) (Human Immuno Deficiency Virus). How did we discover all of this? All of this knowledge was only discovered through inquiry. It specifically looks for event predictions, justifications, connections, and hypotheses. According to Gerald Milburn Scientific inquiry is a chaotic endeavor that stumbles along among false leads, mistakes, and genuinely original insights. Rarely do great scientific discoveries result from a lone researcher laboriously trudging along inexorably toward a specific endpoint. The breakthrough's key concept might emerge several times, in various locations, only to disappear once more beneath the chatter of an interminable scientific discussion. Lundberg (1942) draws a comparison between the method we apply every day and the social research procedure, which is regarded as scientific. He asserts that systematic observation, classification, and data interpretation are all components of scientific procedures. Of course, almost everyone goes through this procedure in the course of their daily life. Our daily generalizations and the findings typically attributed to the scientific method differ primarily in the degree to which:

“1. Formality,

2. Rigorousness,

3. Verifiability,

4. General validity and

5. Reliability of the latter” (Lundberg, 1942, p.5).

Burns (1997, p.2) defines research as “a systematic investigation to find answers to a problem”. According to Kerlinger (1986, p. 10) “Scientific research is a systematic, controlled empirical and critical investigation of propositions about the presumed relationships about various phenomena”. Bulmer (1977, p.5) states: “Nevertheless sociological research, as research, is primarily committed to establishing systematic, reliable and valid knowledge about the social world”. In short, research is “disciplined inquiry” (Dörnyei, 2011, p.15).

However, the extent to which these requirements must be met varies from academic discipline to academic discipline, and as a result, the definition of "research" varies as well. For instance, there are significant differences between the physical and social sciences in terms of expectations for the research

process. In the physical sciences, strong control is expected at every stage of a research project, but in the social sciences, strict control cannot always be imposed and is occasionally not even required.

Because social scientists have different perspectives on the necessity of the research process meeting the aforementioned requirements, the level of control necessary within the social sciences also differed noticeably from one discipline to another. Despite these distinctions between fields, their general methods of inquiry are comparable. This comprehensive approach serves as the foundation for the research model that is the core of this course.

3. What are the Objectives of Research?

The main objectives of research are:

(1) to discover new facts.

(2) To verify and test important facts.

(3) To analyze an event or process or phenomenon to identify the cause and effect relationship.

(4) To develop new scientific tools, concepts and theories to solve and understand scientific and nonscientific problems.

(5) To find solutions to scientific, nonscientific and social problems, and

(6) To overcome or solve the problems occurring in our everyday life.

4. What are the Reasons for doing Research??

This is a critically significant query. Without some sort of motivation, no one would want to conduct study. The following are a few of the reasons: (1) to get a research degree (Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) along with its benefits like better employment, promotion, and increment in salary, etc.

(2) To get a research degree and then to get a teaching position in a college or university or become a scientist in a research institution;

(3) To get a research position in countries like U.S.A., Canada, Germany, England, Japan, Australia, etc. and settle there;

(4) To solve the unsolved and challenging problems;

(5) To get joy of doing some creative work;

(6) To acquire respectability;

(7) To get recognition;

(8) Curiosity to find out the unknown facts of an event;

(9) Curiosity to find new things;

(10) To serve the society by solving social problems.

Some students conduct research without any specific goals, perhaps because they are at a loss for what else to do. Such pupils can motivate themselves toward a legitimate objective and develop into good researchers. Prof. Rajesh Kasturirangan noted that, similar to the tale of the hare and the tortoise, a mind bent toward research would perform better than a mind not trained for it, regardless of whether you work for or manage a corporation. If your intellect has been honed for research, you will resemble a turtle that slowly but steadily makes its way up the mountain to victory.

5. Conclusion:

According to Syed Muhammad Sajjad Kabir (2016), Research is a scientific approach of answering a research question, solving a problem or generating new knowledge through a systematic and orderly collection, organization, and analysis of information with an ultimate goal of making the research useful in decision-making. Systematic research in any field of inquiry involves three basic operations:

1. Data collection: It refers to observing, measuring, and recording information.
2. Data analysis: It refers to arranging and organizing the collected data so that we may be able to find out what their significance is and generalize about them.
3. Report writing: It is an inseparable part and a final outcome of a research study. Its purpose is to convey information contained in it to the readers or audience.

“I keep six serving men,

They taught me all I knew;

Their names are What and Why and When,

And Where and How and Who?" – Rudyard Kipling

6. **Task:**

- Explain the following statements in reverence with the ideas taught in the lecture.
- Booth et., al (2003, p. 10) say that "In the broadest terms, we do research whenever we gather information to answer a question that solves a problem".
- Bassey, M. (1998) defines research as "systematic, critical and self-critical enquiry which aims to contribute to the advancement of knowledge and wisdom"(Quoted in Costello, 2003,p. 3).
- Singh (2006, p. 1) observes the following about research: "Research simply seeks the answer of certain questions which have not been answered so far and the answers depend upon human efforts. It may be illustrated by taking an example of the moon. Some years ago man did not know what exactly the moon is? Was this problem which had no solution? Man could only make some assumptions about it but the man now this time by his efforts, he went to the moon brought the soil of the moon and studied it"

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